

Jargon In My Head

With tonnes of jargons and formats floating around, an average PC is always at sea. So to bust a few technological high bars, here's a brief explanation of concepts and tech fundas.

What is RSS?

It's a dialect of XML. Still puzzled? Read on.

RSS is a format for syndicating news and the content of news-like sites and blogs. The acronym stands for Really Simple Syndication or Rich Site Summary. There is an ongoing dispute between the two camps over the versions RSS 1.0 and RSS 2.0 but then let's not get into that bit.

How do RSS and feed readers work?

RSS files are a type of metadata. Metadata in turn, are units of information commonly used to provide descriptive information about the content, context, and characteristics of data.

An RSS file commonly contains four main types of elements: channel, image, items, and text input. These elements are easy to identify and code. A typical RSS file would read as follows

```
<item>
<title>I Am trying To Understand How A RSS Feed
Works</title>
<link>http://www.thinkdigit.com</link>
```

In a way, feed readers are like conditional access for the end user. For example, a technophile (the propah word for a geek, if you may) would find it really handy to subscribe to a technology Web site like Wired.com and blogs that feature articles on technology such as Slashdot.org or Gizmodo.com. Avid market trackers could surf through multiple feeds coming from Wall Street Journal, Reuters Business or other such business information portals. But the real gainers from this technology are journalists and market or industrial research personnel.

Who Benefits From This?

For a scribe, an aggregator is like his/her own personal news ticker (the infoRSS extension available for Firefox actually looks and works like a television news ticker, as it scrolls across your taskbar). This ticker saves the journalist a lot of time and the trouble of visiting news sites from across the globe. All that needs to be done is subscribe and read off the feed reader.

With the number of blogs increasing at an alarming rate, market research professionals are turning to them for gathering relevant marketing data. The comments left behind on

<description>An RSS-aware programme will track changes and...</description>.

Now a reader is a simple program that tracks changes in the feed and reacts appropriately. A news aggregator will update the feed as per the changes.

What is a news reader?

A news reader is simply a piece of software that you can use to read your subscribed news feeds.

What is a news feed?

A news feed (also known as an RSS feed) is a listing of a Web site's content. It is updated whenever new content is published to the site. News readers "subscribe" to news feeds by downloading lists of content, blogs, tips, stories etc, and present them to you in your news reader. All news feeds will have a link back to the Web site, so if you see a headline/excerpt/story you like, you can click on the link for that piece of content and will be taken to the Web site that generated the news feed to read it.

What is syndication?

Syndication refers to the process that occurs when a publisher provides content in a form that can be consumed by software (like a news reader).

commonly read blogs give a fair inkling to these guys about public perception of a service or a product. By subscribing to these blogs—most blogs generate feeds as a default setting—and sites, a market research cuts down on the time spent combing for relevant data.

How do these tools help Web sites then? Have you ever wondered how Web browsers help Web sites? You see, news aggregators play a very analogous role vis-à-vis Web browsers. One lets you surf sites, the other surfs your feeds for you. Both, develop, increase and accentuate traffic towards the portal (could be a site, could be a blog).

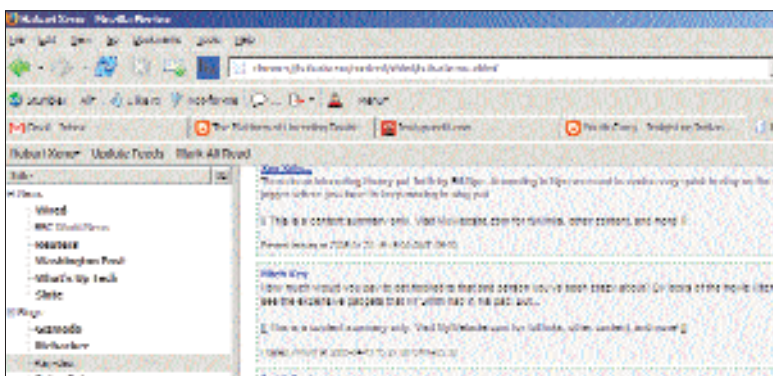
But the aggregator ensures point delivery. If I am a content provider on the net, I can take this reasoning of accurate content delivery to an advertiser and then proceed towards my bank... laughing all the way, of course!

As a Web publisher whose content has been subscribed to via the RSS format, I get a clear picture of what sort of content would appeal to people/readers/users. As a feed provider, you can decide whether to put up all your content as the feed or just a summary.

Also, the software ensures if a person finds an interesting piece of news or post on a Web site, he will be directed to the site on clicking the summary. Google has decided to extend their AdSense programme to RSS feeds as well. Now available as a beta, the procedure is similar to setting up a normal AdSense account (see box *Best Practice Guidelines For AdSense* on previous page).

With the advent of new browsers and technology such as news aggregators, our methods and habits of surfing the Internet will undergo a drastic change. This conditional access will also prompt Web site publishers to come up with innovative approaches to laying out their content. It would also help users decide very quickly what news is the news they can use. ■

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The Habari Xenu Firefox browser integrated news aggregator